From a Pile of Paper to One Page

An ordered plan for organizing Mom's finances: ten actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: you can say what Mom owns, what income she receives and what her care costs each month, with a paper behind each answer and your open questions written down.

Share the list. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Put every statement, bill, policy, tax return and letter you can find in one place, and sort like with like.			
2. List each source of Mom's monthly income: Social Security, pensions, annuities, anything else. Find a paper for each.			
3. List her checking and savings accounts, CDs and money market accounts, and any investment, brokerage or retirement accounts, with a recent statement for each.			
4. List her insurance: life insurance policies, annuities and any long-term care insurance. Find each policy or a recent statement.			
5. List the real estate, vehicles and other significant property, and any business interest. Find the deed, title or registration for each.			
6. List what she owes: a mortgage, loans, credit cards, with a recent statement for each.			
7. Beside every account, policy and property, write whose name is on it and how it is titled, as the paperwork shows. Write “not sure” where you can't tell.			
8. From the latest bill or rate sheet, write down what Mom's care costs each month. Beside it, list her other regular monthly expenses.			
9. Write down any unusual withdrawals, gifts or transfers you come across, with the date and the amount shown. Note them and change nothing.			
10. Next to each open question, write who it goes to: the family, the bank or insurance company, the facility's business office, or your Medicaid planner.			

You're done when

You can say what Mom owns, what income she receives and what her care costs each month. Each answer has a paper behind it or a note saying which paper is still missing, and every open question has a name beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list: adding it up, looking at how far her resources may go, and any decision about what to do. Those belong to the next step and to the professionals who know the rules where Mom lives, and they aren't the family's to do alone.

If something won't turn up

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If a bank or an insurance company can't talk with you yet, write down what they said they need. That is an answer you can bring with you.
- If a line on a bill doesn't make sense, ask the business office to go through it with you, and write down what they say.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's own financial information. It doesn't determine Medicaid eligibility, recommend a legal or financial strategy, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

You've turned a pile of paper into one page. The planning interview is the next step: answer its questions about your family's situation and it gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

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